TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Letter Writing

The business letter, part by part — heading, date, reference, addresses, salutation, body, close and signature — the two standard layouts, and a complete model letter.

HUM-1107 · COMMUNICATIVE ENGLISH · TOPIC 7 · LEVEL 1 TERM 1

1. Why the letter still matters

Email has eaten the letter's speed advantage, but not its functions: the letter remains the formal, signed, archivable instrument of business — the form used for offers, orders, claims, appointments and anything a firm may need to *prove* later. Its conventions are therefore strict, and this topic takes them in the order they meet the reader.

2. The parts of a business letter

PART	CONTENT AND RULES
1. Letterhead / sender's address	The firm's printed head: name, address, phone, email, logo — the sender's identity. (On plain paper, the sender's address is typed at the top, usually right.)
2. Date	Written in full — 12 November 2026 (day month year, the standard order here) — never abbreviated or numeric-only, since 03/04 means different months in different countries.
3. Reference	"Ref: …" — the file/order number that files the letter in both offices' records; a reply quotes the incoming letter's reference ("Your Ref:").
4. Inside address	The receiver's name/designation and full address, exactly as on the envelope.
5. Salutation	"Dear Sir," / "Dear Madam," / "Dear Mr. Rahman," — matched to what is known of the reader; "Dear Sirs" for a firm. The salutation determines the complimentary close (see 7).
6. Subject line	A brief heading naming the letter's business — "Subject: Enquiry about 30s carded yarn" — placed after the salutation (or before it in some styles); the reader knows the topic before the first sentence.
7. Body	The message in (normally) three movements: an opening that states the purpose and links to prior contact; a middle carrying the facts, figures and requests in

	logical paragraphs, one idea each; a close stating the action wanted and a courteous final note.
8. Complimentary close	The formal leave-taking, paired to the salutation: “Yours faithfully” (to Dear Sir/Madam — unnamed) or “Yours sincerely” (to a named person); “Yours truly” is the American variant.
9. Signature block	Signature, then the typed name, designation and (for a firm) “For [Company]” above it when signing on the firm’s behalf.
10. Enclosures & copies	“Encl: Price list (2 pages)” lists attachments; “cc: Accounts Dept.” records who else received the letter.

3. The two standard layouts

- **Block form** (the modern standard): every part begins at the left margin; paragraphs separated by blank lines, no indentation. Clean, fast to type, the default for business and for this course’s examinations.
- **Semi-block / indented form** (the traditional form): paragraphs indented at their first lines, and the date, close and signature placed toward the right. Still seen in formal and government correspondence.

Either form is correct; mixing them within one letter is not. All parts are single-spaced with a blank line between paragraphs, on one side of the paper, with margins that frame the text (about 25 mm).

4. A complete model letter (block form)

Sunrise Textiles Ltd. · 42 Industrial Road, Gazipur · sunrisetextiles@example.com

Ref: ST/PUR/2026/118 | 12 November 2026

The Sales Manager
Delta Dyes & Chemicals
18 Chemical Market, Dhaka

Dear Sir,

Subject: Enquiry about reactive dyes for cotton

We are a knit-dyeing unit processing about five tonnes of cotton fabric daily, and we are looking for a regular supplier of reactive dyes for our production.

Please send us your current price list and technical data sheets for your reactive range suitable for cotton knitwear, together with your terms of payment, minimum order quantity and delivery time to Gazipur. We should also be glad to receive small samples of your navy and black shades for laboratory testing.

We look forward to your quotation by 20 November 2026 and hope this will be the beginning of regular business between our firms.

Yours faithfully,

(signature)
Md. Ariful Islam
Purchase Manager
For Sunrise Textiles Ltd.

Encl: Company profile (1 page)

Read the model against §2: every part is present and in its place, the body runs opening → particulars → courteous action close, and the reference, date and subject let both offices file and find the letter again — the letter as a working instrument, not an essay.

5. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Letterhead	The printed heading of a firm’s stationery carrying its name and address.
Inside address	The receiver’s name and address as part of the letter itself.
Salutation	The greeting line (“Dear Sir,”) that opens the letter proper.
Complimentary close	The formal ending (“Yours faithfully,”) paired with the salutation.
Block form	The layout in which all parts start at the left margin.
Enclosure (Encl.)	A document sent with the letter, listed at its foot.

6. Key points and summary

- A business letter is a standard machine of ten parts — head, date, reference, inside address, salutation, subject, body, close, signature, enclosures — in fixed order.
- Block form is the modern layout; semi-block the traditional; consistency within the letter is the rule.

- The body moves in three: state the purpose, carry the facts, close with the action wanted.

7. Practice

Written and drafting exercises; brief model answers follow.

1. List the ten parts of a business letter in order, and state which two are commonly supplied by the printed letterhead and the typist's routine rather than composed fresh.
2. Pair the closes: "Dear Sir," → ? ; "Dear Ms. Akter," → ? — and explain the rule.
3. Draft the body (three paragraphs) of a letter from a college textile society inviting a mill manager to deliver a talk — dates and details of your choosing, clearly invented for practice.
4. Find the faults in this opening: "3/4/26 — Sir, Sub: price. With ref to ur letter we beg to say that…" List at least four violations of this topic's standards.
5. Why is the date written in full rather than as numbers?
6. Convert this semi-block description into block form: state the three layout changes required.
7. What do "Encl." and "cc" at a letter's foot tell its reader, and why does the writer bother?

Answer key

1. Letterhead/sender's address; date; reference; inside address; salutation; subject line; body; complimentary close; signature block; enclosures/copies. Supplied by routine: the letterhead (printed) and the reference/date (office routine).
2. "Dear Sir," → "Yours faithfully"; "Dear Ms. Akter," → "Yours sincerely". Rule: an unnamed salutation takes faithfully; a named one takes sincerely.
3. Model shape: ¶1 — who writes and the invitation with its occasion; ¶2 — date, time, venue, audience, topic suggested, duration; ¶3 — request for confirmation by a date, thanks, and an offer to arrange transport/details. Any consistent invented details earn the marks; the three-movement body is what is being tested.
4. Numeric abbreviated date (ambiguous and informal); missing "Dear" and casual salutation; "Sub:" telegraphic style; "ur" text-speak; the archaic begging formula "we beg to say" — all contrary to the full-date, courteous, direct standards of §§2–3.
5. Because numeric dates are ambiguous between conventions (03/04/26 = 3 April here, March 4 in the USA) — the full form, 3 April 2026, can be misread by no one, and the letter may be evidence years later.
6. (1) Bring the date and the close/signature block to the left margin; (2) remove first-line indentation of paragraphs; (3) separate paragraphs by blank lines instead.

7. “Encl.” tells the reader exactly what else should be in the envelope (so a missing item is caught at opening); “cc” tells them who else holds the letter (so replies can be coordinated) — both are the letter’s filing machinery.
